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The Veil of Gender: De-Sensationalizing the Lethality of Female Suicide Terrorism

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Abstract

Popular belief suggests that female suicide terrorists cause more fatalities than their male counterparts. The argument for the superiority of female lethality largely derives from qualitative research, such as anecdotal episodes or small-*n* case studies, though quantitative research continues to grow. While qualitative studies provide detailed insights into the behaviors of female suicide bombers, the findings can be difficult to generalize. This short essay presents a quantitative examination to assess the validity of this prevailing belief. First, we put forth a brief theoretical discussion: female bombers merely replace depleted male cadres, exhibiting little active participation or inadequate training and, thus, no greater lethality. Second, we perform empirical testing based on an original, incident-level dataset of 6,800 suicide attacks during the period from 1985 through 2017. Our large-*n* quantitative analysis contradicts the widely held belief in the literature and reveals that female suicide bombers inflict fewer fatalities than their male counterparts.

Resumen

La creencia popular sugiere que las terroristas suicidas provocan más víctimas que los terroristas masculinos. La hipótesis relativa a la superioridad de la letalidad femenina se deriva, en gran medida, de investigaciones cualitativas que incluyen episodios anecdóticos o estudios de caso con un pequeño número de participantes. Sin embargo, la investigación cuantitativa sigue en aumento. Aunque los estudios cualitativos proporcionan información detallada sobre los comportamientos de las mujeres suicidas, los hallazgos pueden ser difíciles de generalizar. Este breve ensayo presenta un examen cuantitativo que tiene por objetivo evaluar la validez de esta creencia predominante. En primer lugar, presentamos una breve discusión teórica: las ≪mujeres bomba≫ simplemente reemplazan a los cuadros masculinos agotados, muestran poca participación activa o entrenamiento insuficiente y, por lo tanto, no generan una mayor letalidad. En segundo lugar, llevamos a cabo pruebas empíricas basadas en un conjunto de datos original a nivel de incidentes que recoge 6800 ataques suicidas que tuvieron lugar entre 1985 y 2017. Nuestro análisis cuantitativo a gran escala contradice esta creencia, ampliamente aceptada en la literatura, y revela que las mujeres bomba suicidas causan menos muertes que los hombres bomba.

Résumé

L'on s'imagine généralement que les terroristes suicides féminins provoquent davantage de victimes que leurs homologues masculins. L'argument de la supériorité de la létalité féminine provient largement de la recherche qualitative, par exemple de l'étude d'épisodes anecdotiques ou de cas petit N, bien que la recherche quantitative continue de s'enrichir. Alors que les études qualitatives nous renseignent en détail sur le comportement des femmes kamikazes, leurs conclusions peuvent s'avérer difficiles à généraliser. Ce court essai présente un examen quantitatif visant à évaluer la validité de cette croyance majoritaire. D'abord, nous proposons une brève discussion théorique: les femmes kamikazes ne font que combler les pertes d'effectifs masculins, ne s'impliquent pas souvent activement et ne disposent pas de la formation adéquate. Leur létalité n'est donc pas plus importante. Ensuite, nous réalisons un test empirique fondé sur un ensemble de données inédit à l'échelle de l'incident sur 6800 attentats-suicides entre 1985 et 2017. Notre analyse quantitative grand N vient contredire la croyance majoritaire de la littérature, car elle révèle que les femmes kamikazes font moins de décès que leurs homologues masculins.

Key words: female suicide terrorism; lethality; fatality; gender; large-*n* statistical analysis.

Palabras clave: terrorismo suicida femenino; letalidad; mortalidad; género; análisis estadístico a gran escala.

Mots clés: terrorisme suicide féminin; létalité; nombre de victimes; genre; analyse statistique grand N.

Introduction

In recent years, the lethal superiority of female attackers has gained prominence among scholars and policy-makers.[1] Researchers underscore that female suicide bombers represent an increasing threat and kill more people on average than male bombers (e.g., Stack-O'Connor 2007; O'Rourke 2009; Davis 2013; Margolin 2016; Choi 2025).[2] In particular, Bloom (2011, 7) asserts that "female terrorists are often the deadliest because of the element of surprise. . . They kill, on average, four times more people than their male counterparts." Yet, many existing studies offer little generalizable empirical evidence across time and geography and instead largely provide anecdotal episodes or small-*n* analyses, such as interviews of failed female bombers or family members of bombers to perform "psychological autopsies"[3] and uncover "general" motivations (Victor 2003; Berko 2007). They also tend to make claims about supposed differences between male and female bombers based on descriptive statistics (Schweitzer 2006; O'Rourke 2009; Bloom 2011; Davis 2013; Soules 2022a),[4] but shy away from modeling the effects of gender differences on the suicide-attack phenomenon in large-*n* statistical analyses (for exceptions, see Alakoc 2020; Thomas 2021).

In this short essay, we offer a large-*n* empirical examination, investigating whether the lethal superiority of female attackers holds true. First, we put forth a brief theoretical discussion: female bombers do not inflict superior lethality because organizations tend to dispatch them as replacements for male bombers whose numbers have depleted due to counterterrorism efforts, as well as offer them little tactical training for inflicting optimal damage. Second, we conduct a large-*n* empirical study of female suicide bombers, analyzing an original dataset of 6,800 suicide attacks for the years 1985–2017. The statistical models reveal that, contrary to popular belief, female suicide attacks are not more lethal than male suicide attacks.

Explaining the Lethality of Female Suicide Terrorists

Since we purport to empirically challenge popular beliefs about the lethality of female suicide terrorists, our theory discussion simply reviews why numerous existing studies consider women to be more lethal than men. Victor (2003, 8) contends that the female suicide bomber represents "an example of the exploitation of women taken to a cynical and lethal extreme." This implies that female bombers gain tactical advantages because security personnel view women with less suspicion. Police officers and soldiers often give female bombers the benefit of the doubt, permitting them to reach targets male bombers might not reach as easily. Especially when women appear pregnant or accompanied by children, security personnel struggle to surmise that such women might also have a suicide belt strapped to them. Due to these tactical advantages, even male bombers sometimes disguise themselves as women to get closer to targets or evade search by the enemy security apparatus (O'Rourke 2009; Berko 2012). Because the widespread presumed innocence of women provides quick and easy access to their targets, female suicide attacks likely inflict more damage and therefore kill more people (Cunningham 2007; Speckhard 2008; O'Rourke 2009; Davis 2013). Others contextualize the superiority of female lethality by a society's cultural acceptance of women in public spaces (Thomas 2021; Soules 2022b). These arguments rest on the assumption that female bombers match their male counterparts in competence when executing suicide attacks, and that socio-cultural norms portraying women as nonviolent help them carry out deadlier missions.

Various recent studies of rebel-organization membership empirically establish the pervasive dominance of men in the formalized and trained ranks of organizations (Acosta, Huang, and Silverman 2022; Huang, Silverman, and Acosta 2022; Silverman, Acosta, and Huang 2024). We contend that organizations often train female suicide bombers poorly, if at all, and consequently, their attacks inflict less damage than those of their male counterparts. Research suggests that many male operatives undergo ideological indoctrination and structured preparation before attacks (Hafez 2006; Santifort-Jordan and Sandler 2014), though this training likely varies by organization, ideology, and time. Nevertheless, Orbach (2004, 125) notes that "not all suicide bombers go through this lengthy process. In some cases, especially with women, the procedure is hasty and abrupt." Similarly, Patkin (2004, 87) observes that "a volunteer female suicide bomber typically trains for a period of only two to eight weeks, depending on the woman involved, far less than the months-long male course." Organizations generally deploy female bombers in efforts to replace male cadres who grow scarce due to counter-terrorism and counter-insurgency efforts. For example, in Iraq and Syria, with the depletion

[1] We define a *suicide attack* as an act of political violence that targets either a civilian or military target where the perpetrator intended to die at the operation's onset.

[2] Thayer and Hudson (2010, 191) suggest that even the "obstructed marriage markets" of the Islamic world do not deincentivize organizations from recruiting female bombers due to the tactical advantages they offer.

[3] Coined in Weisman and Kastenbaum (1968). See also Lester, Yang, and Mark Lindsey (2004).

[4] O'Rourke (2009) goes beyond basic statistics, but she bases models exclusively on five conflicts that involved suicide attacks.

of male cadres in their losing battles and intense competition over recruiting fighting-age men, the Islamic State replenished its ranks by turning to female recruits (Davis 2013; Mostafa 2017; Roberts 2017). Another example comes from the Liberation Front of Tamil Eelam, which recruited women when the organization "faced a supply and demand problem" (Stack-O'Connor 2007, 57).

The first female suicide attacks occurred amid Lebanon's Civil War in 1985, five years after the first contemporary suicide bomber. At that time, in Lebanon's hyper-conflict zone, as organizations could not replace male fighters as quickly as they fell on the battlefield, they recruited women for combat roles out of necessity (Parkinson 2013). The Syrian Social-Nationalist Party employed multiple average young Lebanese women to carry out suicide attacks (Schweitzer 2006). Taking place during Lebanon's "War of the Camps," four teenage girls became the first Palestinian suicide bombers—attacking fighters from the Lebanese-Shi'a organization Amal (Acosta 2016). In 2002, the first Palestinian female suicide bomber to strike an Israeli target came about by accident as explosives she smuggled on her person detonated in transit (Victor 2003; Schweitzer 2006). The attack immediately gained the praise of Fatah's leader, Yasser Arafat, and helped to set off a competition among Palestinian terrorist organizations (Victor 2003; Bloom 2005). In other places like Russia, Sri Lanka, and Afghanistan, high degrees of conflict brought similar shifts to organizations employing female suicide attackers.

Once recruited or abducted, some organizations may provide women with limited tactical training for suicide attacks, particularly when facing cadre shortages (Bloom 2011; Berko 2012; Warner and Matfess 2017). In Nigeria, Boko Haram's abduction and coercion of young girls contribute directly to women launching scores of suicide attacks (Jacques and Taylor 2008; Bloom 2011; Nolen 2016; Searcey 2017; Markovic 2019). Despite being notorious for exploiting hundreds of women in its suicide attacks, Boko Haram has deployed many underage or coerced female bombers with little training, which explains the relatively lower lethality of some of these attacks (Warner and Matfess 2017; Markovic 2019). Many abducted women remain difficult to indoctrinate and unwilling to participate in suicide-bombing training from the start and often abandon their missions on the spot out of fear (Warner, Chapin, and Matfess 2019). For example, in December 2016, Boko Haram abducted and deployed two young girls without any training. The organization simply strapped suicide vests on their chests; as such, the mission failed (Smith 2016). Notably, Schweitzer (2006, 9) observes that while women "arouse less suspicion," they more so "offer an inefficient use of human resources." Simply put, the insufficient training of operational substitutes likely offsets any advantages gained by women garnering less suspicion. Therefore, we formulate our hypothesis as follows:

H_1: Female suicide bombers are less likely to inflict more lethal attacks than their male counterparts.

Research Design

Relying on a larger universe of suicide attacks than existing datasets, we follow other leading studies (e.g., Acosta and Childs 2013; Acosta 2014; 2016; Acosta and Ramos 2017; Barceló and Labzina 2020; Choi and Acosta 2020) and analyze the Suicide-Attack Network Database (SAND). We update the dataset by coding each suicide attack event; we identify whether a male or female suicide bomber carried out the attack. With this new variable, the novel dataset we work from documents 6,822 incidents during the period from 1980 through 2017. Yet, to consider the fact that the first female bombing occurred in 1985, we confine the following analyses to a sample of 6,800 incidents for the years 1985–2017.[5] The unit of analysis is individual suicide bombing incidents since our study focuses on the lethality of individual female bombers.

As we are interested in whether female suicide bombers inflict more deadly attacks than their male counterparts, we measure the dependent variable as the degree of lethality of each suicide attack in terms of the number of individuals killed and wounded, calculated and tested separately. We first consider Poisson regression as the dependent variable is a count measure. However, the Pearson goodness-of-fit chi-squared test reveals statistical significance ($\chi^2 = 253{,}978.6$, $p < 0.0000$), indicating that Poisson regression does not fit the data well because the variance is much larger than the mean.[6] Alternatively, we use negative binomial maximum-likelihood regressions with Huber-White robust standard errors clustered by country. Negative binomial regression adds a dispersion parameter to model the unobserved heterogeneity among observations, correcting for the overdispersion found in Poisson models. We incorporate year fixed-effects into the model to account for the temporal effect

[5] SAND is accessible at *www.revolutionarymilitant.org*. The collection of SAND is primarily based on English, Arabic, and Hebrew sources, which may induce some bias. Nevertheless, SAND's *N* remains far greater than that of other datasets such as Chicago Project on Suicide Terrorism (CPOST; *cpost-data.uchicago.edu*, 5,430 observations) and Santifort-Jordan and Sandler (2014, 2,448 observations).

[6] In Online Appendix Figure 1, we illustrate two box plots for the number of individuals killed and wounded by gender. The figure shows that the mean is much smaller than the variance for men.

that organizations tend to deploy female bombers after targets have hardened over the years.[7] We also add country fixed-effects since the quality of state counter-terrorism forces varies significantly by country.

The main independent variable is the gender of the attacker, coded as "1" for a female bomber and "0" otherwise.[8] Our sample of 6,800 suicide attacks contains 441 of the suicide attacks that were perpetrated by female bombers. Since women represent a small fraction of the total suicide attacks, we infer that terrorist organizations prefer men over women as suicide bombers. This preference, however, may reflect broader societal gender norms that position women outside combat roles rather than assumptions about superior male effectiveness—similar to how gendered occupational patterns emerge in civilian contexts in most civilizations. Another possibility is that fewer women want to be suicide bombers, not that they are preferred, which is a supply-side explanation rather than a demand-side one.

The empirical analyses also include control variables commonly found in the literature on suicide terrorism (e.g., Atran 2003; Bloom 2005; Hafez 2006; Abrahms 2010, 2012; Acosta 2014, 2016; Choi and Piazza 2017; Choi and Acosta 2020). To control for Economic Development (Choi and Luo 2013; Choi 2014, 2015, 2019), we log the World Bank's 2018 GDP per capita as measured in constant 2010 dollars.[9] To account for income inequality, we use Solt's (2016) Gini index, which measures national income inequality from 0 to 100. Outbidding theory suggests that competition among militant organizations for support drives the proliferation of suicide attacks (Choi 2018, Chapter 4). Thus, we develop the variable Militant Outbidding, counting the number of rival organizations in specific conflict zones. We also code and analyze the following binary variables: whether the suicide bomber operated on behalf of an Islamic Militant Organization as opposed to a non-Islamic one, an International Militant Organization as opposed to a solely domestic organization, whether the bomber attacked a Muslim Target as opposed to a non-Muslim target,[10] a Domestic Target as opposed to a foreign one, a Civilian Target as opposed to a combatant, and whether the attack occurred under Foreign Military Occupation (Choi 2016, 2025; Choi and Piazza 2017; Piazza and Choi 2018; Choi and Acosta 2020; Choi and Brown 2022). With the last variable, we rely on the Polity category that records cases of foreign "interruption" (Marshall, Gurr, and Jaggers 2018).

Empirical Results

Table 1 shows the results of negative binomial regressions that test the lethality of female suicide attacks as measured by the total number of killed and wounded, respectively. The minimum number of killed is 0, and the maximum is 2,749; the minimum number of wounded is 0, and the maximum is 5,000. On average, male suicide bombers kill nineteen people, whereas female suicide bombers kill thirteen. This basic statistic counters the popular belief about the lethal superiority of female bombers.

Table 1 provides three sets of negative binomial regression models. The first set is bivariate regression models to evaluate the effect of Female Suicide Bombing on Killed (Model 1) and Wounded (Model 4); the second set replicates the first set after adding country and year fixed-effects; the third set re-estimates the second set after adding all the control variables. It appears that the Female Suicide Bombing variable either achieves significance with a negative sign or fails to achieve significance. This means that female suicide bombers tend not to carry out deadlier attacks than male bombers.[11] Models 1–4 show evidence that female attackers are less lethal than their male counterparts.[12] This result contrasts with the conventional wisdom that emphasizes the tactical advantages of female suicide bombers.[13]

[7] The fixed effect is over years, not terrorist campaigns. As a robustness check, we measure the duration of each terrorist campaign and interact it with Female Suicide Bombing. Online Appendix 1 displays the estimated results and Online Appendix Figure 2 illustrates the substantive effects of female bombers in terrorist campaign-related variables. We can infer from the estimated results that female bombers inflict less deadly attacks as they are brought in terrorist campaigns when the odds of success are lower due to a shortage of men over the years.

[8] To identify the gender of suicide bombers, we used SAND and various internet sources. When we could not confirm the gender, we coded it as male because female bombers should have been widely publicized, given the fact that they are likely to receive significantly more media attention than their male counterparts (Avraham 2016; Soules 2022a). Alakoc (2020) employs the same coding strategy for the unidentified. When the unconfirmed observations of gender are excluded from the sample, the main findings of this study do not alter so that they are reported due to the page limit.

[9] See Choi (2015) for a similar approach.

[10] We include this variable because targeting co-religionists viewed as heretics carries distinct reputational and strategic consequences that may independently influence efforts to maximize lethality (Acosta 2016). Note that a Muslim Target identifies a target selected by a terrorist organization that may be Islamic or non-Islamic. The correlation between these two variables is only 0.20.

[11] It is interesting to know whether female bombers are less deadly than their male counterpart when they live in a conservative society. Online Appendix 2 and Online Appendix Figure 3 indicate that their lethality decreases, which aligns with the main findings of this short essay. However, the findings are the opposite of what Thomas (2021) finds. The discrepancy comes from the different sample sizes. Our sample includes 6,800 suicide attacks, while Thomas uses 2,373 out of 5,939 observations for 1985–2015, gathered from the CPOST (i.e., selection bias).

[12] Whether female bombers from Islamist terrorist organizations are less deadly than non-Islamic ones is an intriguing issue. Online Appendix 3 and Online Appendix Figure 4 indicate that they are.

[13] The sample may include significant outliers, so it is important to know whether the results are robust to the exclusion of

Table 1. Are female suicide bombings more lethal than male suicide bombings?

	Negative binomial regression					
	Killed			Wounded		
Variable	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
Female suicide bombing	−0.422***	−0.252**	−0.278***	−0.394***	−0.023	−0.043
	(0.071)	(0.080)	(0.081)	(0.075)	(0.078)	(0.079)
Economic development			−0.087			−0.025
			(0.056)			(0.055)
Income inequality			0.037***			0.006
			(0.011)			(0.012)
Foreign military occupation			0.072			0.030
			(0.068)			(0.079)
Militant outbidding			0.018			0.015
			(0.023)			(0.026)
Islamic Militant Organization			0.155*			0.100
			(0.071)			(0.075)
International Militant Org.			0.029			−0.117
			(0.067)			(0.072)
Muslim target			0.344***			0.271**
			(0.076)			(0.085)
Domestic target			0.135			0.029
			(0.086)			(0.090)
Civilian target			0.489***			0.455***
			(0.031)			(0.033)
Constant	2.130***	1.777***	0.175	2.933***	2.403***	1.858*
	(0.057)	(0.106)	(0.705)	(0.052)	(0.110)	(0.782)
Country fixed-effects	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Year fixed-effects	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Wald Chi^2	35.09	401.46	748.08	27.77	807.67	932.26
Prob > Chi^2	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Log Pseudolikelihood	−18,962.79	18,769.23	18,579.72	22,036.06	21,625.65	21,492.26
Pseudo R^2	0.001	0.011	0.021	0.001	0.019	0.025
Observations	6,800	6,800	6,800	6,800	6,800	6,800

Note: Robust standard errors in parentheses.
*$p < 0.05$.
**$p < 0.01$.
***$p < 0.001$, two-tailed tests.

We proceed to answer whether the effects of female bombers on lethality differ when the targets are limited to civilians or combatants. Female bombers accept their own death as a direct result of the method used to harm, damage, or destroy the target, but the lethality from civilian targets should be different from that of combatant ones because women are, due to their gender, more easily able to blend in and successfully terrorize the former than the latter. To test these expectations, we divide our sample into two target groups: civilians and combatants. The first sub-sample tests lethality stemming from civilian targets, and the second sub-sample from combatant targets. Table 2 indicates that the reduced effectiveness of female bombers appears to result from their ineffectiveness in striking military targets. The effect of gender on civilian targets is not significant. Overall, the results are compelling evidence disputing the popular belief that female suicide bombings are more lethal than male suicide bombers.

It is possible that the control variables may serve as intervening variables rather than confounders—i.e., any effect of female suicide bombing lethality may operate via one of them. In this case, the nuanced assumption suggests a direct effect of Female Suicide Bombing on Lethality and an indirect effect of each of the control variables on Lethality. Employing the Stata command, ldecomp, that decomposes total effects in logistic regression into direct and indirect effects (Buis 2010), we conduct a mediation analysis. When the dependent variable is Killed, the Military Outbidding variable, out of the nine control variables, is the only one that exerts a relatively important, indirect effect on Lethality. Economic Development, Islamic Militant Organization, and

the observations. Online Appendix 4, where outliers are dropped, does not deviate from the main findings of table 1.

Table 2. Female suicide bombings and lethality: Civilians versus combatants

	Negative binomial regression			
	Killed		Wounded	
Variable	Civilians Model 1	Combatants Model 2	Civilians Model 3	Combatants Model 4
Female suicide bombing	−0.110	−0.554***	0.064	−0.186
	(0.102)	(0.142)	(0.106)	(0.133)
Economic development	0.140	−0.255**	0.112	−0.073
	(0.080)	(0.081)	(0.078)	(0.076)
Income inequality	0.062***	0.019	0.028	−0.017
	(0.018)	(0.014)	(0.019)	(0.016)
Foreign military occupation	−0.054	0.191	−0.158	0.206
	(0.087)	(0.107)	(0.106)	(0.119)
Militant outbidding	0.049	−0.006	0.031	−0.006
	(0.036)	(0.030)	(0.039)	(0.035)
Islamic Militant Organization	0.149	0.181	0.095	0.122
	(0.100)	(0.100)	(0.110)	(0.102)
International Militant Org.	0.151	−0.078	−0.058	−0.165
	(0.097)	(0.090)	(0.106)	(0.097)
Muslim target	0.346***	0.301*	0.382***	0.105
	(0.096)	(0.135)	(0.115)	(0.141)
Domestic target	0.171	0.271	0.319*	0.164
	(0.119)	(0.144)	(0.151)	(0.145)
Constant	−2.492*	2.211*	−0.099	3.132**
	(1.182)	(0.878)	(1.185)	(1.039)
Country fixed-effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year fixed-effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Wald Chi^2	469.10	not estimated	not estimated	1460.95
Prob > Chi^2	0.000	not estimated	not estimated	0.000
Log Pseudolikelihood	−10,445.13	−7982.18	−12,031.91	−9334.42
Pseudo R^2	0.016	0.027	0.021	0.033
Observations	3,369	3,431	3,369	3,431

Note: Robust standard errors in parentheses.
*$p < 0.05$.
**$p < 0.01$.
***$p < 0.001$, two-tailed tests.

International Militant Organization turn out to generate no meaningful indirect effects. When the dependent variable is Wounded, Military Outbidding, Income Inequality, and Foreign Military Occupation are the three variables that exert a significant indirect effect on Lethality. Islamic Militant Organization and Domestic Target appear to produce no indirect effect.

To economize space, table 3 shows selected results from the mediation analysis where the effect of the Female Suicide Bombing variable on the outcome variable, Lethality, is mediated through the Military Outbidding variable. Terrorist organizations can employ female bombers to outbid rivals by taking advantage of stereotypes that depict women as passive or non-violent. This tactic enables them to navigate security checkpoints more easily and achieve high levels of lethality. The sizes of the indirect effects relative to the total effects are shown at the bottom of the decomposition table. These are labeled 1/0r. On average, the indirect effect is 40 percent of the total effect when the outcome variable is Killed (Model 1) and 65 percent when the outcome variable is Wounded (Model 2). The overall mediation analysis indicates that there is a negative, but not positive, relationship between Female Suicide Bombing and Lethality that operates via Military Outbidding. Thus, this result, once again, runs counter to the popular belief that female suicide bombers are more lethal than male suicide bombers.

Conclusion

This short essay seeks to de-sensationalize the popular narrative surrounding the presumably superior lethality of female suicide bombers with an empirical lens. The popular belief has formed largely from anecdotal episodes or small-*n* studies of female suicide attacks. Yet, such research has rarely been confirmed with longitudinal individual data and thereby falls short of offering generalizable re-

Table 3. Effect of female suicide bombing on lethality via militant outbidding: Mediation analysis

Variable		Ldecomp Killed Model 1	Ldecomp Wounded Model 2
1/0			
	Total	−0.653***	−0.559***
		(0.117)	(0.106)
	Indirect1	−0.260***	−0.360***
		(0.030)	(0.032)
	Direct1	−0.393***	−0.199
		(0.114)	(0.110)
	Indirect2	−0.260***	−0.360***
		(0.030)	(0.033)
	Direct2	−0.393***	−0.199
		(0.114)	(0.110)
1/0r			
	Method1	0.399***	0.645***
		(0.081)	(0.158)
	Method2	0.398***	0.644***
		(0.081)	(0.158)
	Average	0.399***	0.644***
		(0.081)	(0.158)
Observations		6,800	6,800

Note: Bootstrap standard errors in parentheses.
*$p < 0.05$.
**$p < 0.01$.
***$p < 0.001$, two-tailed tests.

sults across time and geography (exceptions include Alakoc 2020; Thomas 2021). By departing from case-based approaches, collecting an original dataset on individual female suicide terrorists, and performing a large quantitative analysis, we challenge the popular belief. We find empirical results that starkly contradict the popular belief that female suicide bombers carry out more lethal attacks than their male counterparts. Our overall analyses demonstrate that when women conduct suicide attacks, they are not more deadly than those carried out by men. Notably, female suicide bombers are not as lethal as widely popularized because organizations recruit them out of operational necessity with the depletion of male cadres rather than from strategic or tactical preferences.

Although further investigation is needed to understand why women, who are conceived as cheaper substitutes and receive less training compared to men, tend to inflict less lethal attacks, we believe that our original collection of terrorist data and a battery of empirical analyses represent a valid and vital contribution to the study of international security in that the main findings negate the claims made in previous case studies, journalist accounts, and popular stories. Taking our analysis into account, the counterterrorism community should recognize that the lethal superiority of female bombers is a myth that mass media has sensationalized and popularized. Rather than perceiving female bombers through sensationalist lenses that amplify misconceptions, scholars and policymakers should recognize the nuanced reality: female suicide attackers pose a genuine threat but are not inherently more deadly than their male counterparts. Understanding this distinction not only contributes to better-informed counter-terrorism strategies but also fosters a more accurate view of female bombers engaging in terrorist violence.

Supplementary material

Supplementary material is available at the *Journal of Global Security Studies* online.

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